

DECISIVE MOMENT

BATTLE OF CARABOBO, 1821

On June 24, 1821, independence fighters led by Simón Bolívar defeated Spanish royalists on the plains to the west of Caracas. Bolívar is shown here accepting the standard after a victory that all but freed Venezuela from Spanish control, with independence finally assured two years later. Breaking the terms of an armistice he had signed with the Spanish government in November 1820, Bolívar had attacked the royalist garrison on Lake Maracaibo. The two armies met on the plains of Carabobo, where Bolívar's forces routed the remaining Spaniards under General Miguel de la Torre; only 400 escaped out of 5,000.



1960 Movement of the Revolutionary Left (MIR) splits from the AD and begins antigovernment activities.

1960 Venezuela becomes a founding member of the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC).

1962 Communist-backed guerrilla warfare attempts repetition of Cuban revolution in Venezuela, but fails to gain sufficient popular support.

1963 Raúl Leoni (AD) is elected president in the first-ever democratic transfer of power. Antiguerilla campaign continues.

1966 Unsuccessful coup attempt by supporters of former president Pérez Jiménez.

1969 Rafael Caldera Rodríguez of the Social Christian Party (COPEI) becomes president. Continues Leoni's policies.

1973 Oil and steel industries nationalized during the world oil crisis. Venezuelan currency peaks against the US dollar.

1978 Elections won by COPEI's Luis Herrera Campíns. Disastrous economic programs harm economy.

1983 Election victory under Jaime Lusinchi (AD). A sharp fall in world oil prices leads to cuts in state welfare and social unrest.

1988–89 Carlos Andrés Pérez wins elections for AD. Venezuela takes out an IMF loan and initiates an austerity program. In the Caracas food riots, 1,500 die. Martial law is declared.

1992 Hugo Chávez leads a failed coup attempt. He later forms the Fifth Republic Movement (MVR) to gain power.

1993–95 Andrés Pérez ousted on charges of corruption. Caldera Rodríguez is reelected amid growing social unrest.

1998–99 Hugo Chávez's MVR-led coalition defeats the COPEI-led coalition in elections. Chávez embarks on a "Bolivarian Revolution" of social and political reform, using oil revenues to fund education and health programs.

2006 Chávez wins presidential election, taking almost two-thirds of the vote.

2007 Plans are announced to nationalize the energy supply and telecommunications industries. Chávez narrowly loses referendum on extending his constitutional changes.

2010 The opposition makes gains in parliamentary elections, although Chávez still commands a majority in Congress.

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Oil wealth

Venezuela has the largest proven oil reserves of any country outside the Middle East, much of it centered around Lake Maracaibo (above). High oil revenues have funded President Chávez's ambitious program of social reform.

Guyana



A former British colony, Guyana is the only English-speaking nation on the continent.

1499 The coast is explored by Alonso de Ojeda on Columbus's third voyage.

1530s The search for El Dorado centers on the Amazon and Orinoco areas.

1616 A Dutch expedition under Adrian Groenewegen establishes a fort at Kykoveral, where Dutch settlers arrive in 1624. Both England and France establish colonies in the region.

1648 Under the Treaty of Munster, Spain recognizes Berbice and Essequibo, including Demerara, as Dutch colonies.

1667 By the Treaty of Breda, the Dutch gain all English colonies in Guyana.

1814 The Dutch colonies come under English control and in 1831 are united as British Guiana, the first and only British colony in South America.

1850s The UK imports laborers from India to add to the large number of freed slaves originally brought over from Africa from the 17th century onward.

1879 Gold is discovered, prompting UK expansion and a boundary dispute with Venezuela only settled in 1904; Venezuela still claims western Guyana.

1953 First universal elections won by the People's Progressive Party (PPP) under Cheddi Jagan; parliament later suspended by UK.

1964 People's National Congress (PNC) dominates ruling coalition parties.

1966 Independence from UK as a republic within the Commonwealth.

1973 PPP boycotts parliament, accusing the PNC of electoral fraud.

1992 Fair elections won by PPP: Jagan is reelected president.

1997–98 Jagan dies in office. The PNC rejects his widow Janet's election victory. A political crisis erupts until she is accepted as president.

1999 Caricom—the Caribbean Community and Common Market—brokers a peace deal. Janet Jagan resigns due to illness.

2001 Political violence flares again when Bharrat Jagdeo of the PPP wins the presidential election. Tensions remain high until the PNC leader, Desmond Hoyte, dies in 2003.

2006 Bharrat Jagdeo wins a new presidential term.

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Suriname



This former Dutch colony is the smallest country in South America but ethnically very diverse.

1667 Dutch rule begins after the Treaty of Breda between the Netherlands and England recognizes Dutch rule in Guiana.

1975 Independence from the Netherlands.

1980 Military coup: rule by Lieutenant Colonel Desi Bouterse. A National Military Council is established to run the country. Further coup attempts occur in 1981 and 1982.

1982 Political opponents are executed. The Dutch suspend aid for six years.

1986–92 Maroon rebels of the Suriname Liberation Army wage war.

1987 A new constitution is approved in a referendum.

1988 Elections return Suriname to democracy.

1990 A further military coup deposes the government. A peace agreement is signed with the rebels in 1992.

1991–96 A coalition New Front for Democracy and Development (NF) government representing Creoles, South Asians, and Javanese peoples takes power under Ronald Venetiaan of the Suriname National Party.

1992 Bouterse quits as head of the army, easing tensions in the country.

1996 Jules Wijdenbosch of the opposition National Democratic Party (NDP) and an ally of Bouterse wins power but refuses to extradite Bouterse to the Netherlands on drug charges.

2000 Opposition NF wins elections under Ronald Venetiaan. He cuts public spending, and starts a process of reform.

2004 The Dutch guilder is replaced by the Suriname dollar; reforms restructure the important banana industry.

2004 UN mediates in a maritime border dispute with Guyana.

2005 Ronald Venetiaan wins reelection to the presidency.

2007 At least 250,000 Surinamese now live abroad. Most live in the Netherlands, boosting the national economy with remittances. Of the home population of 450,000, more than 90 percent live near the coast, the rest in scattered villages in the interior.

2010 Former President Bouterse wins presidential elections.

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